

# Scaling customer acquisition for a global retail SaaS platform

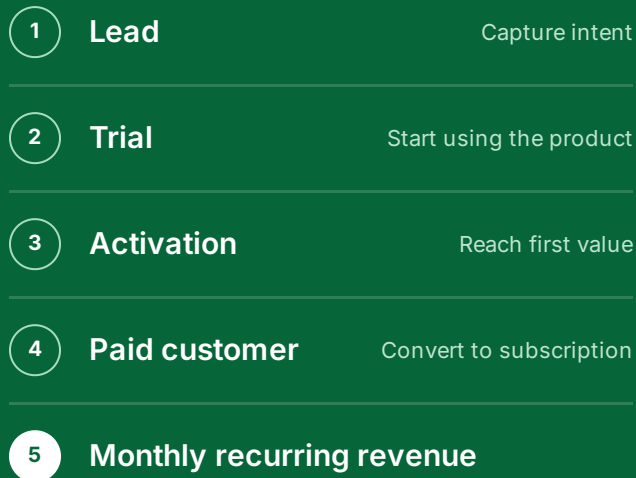
How a fast-growing New Zealand cloud software company used search, funnel design, market prioritisation and measurement to build a more scalable acquisition engine.



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## THE SAAS REVENUE CYCLE



# Vend brought SaaS to physical retail

## A cloud-native retail platform

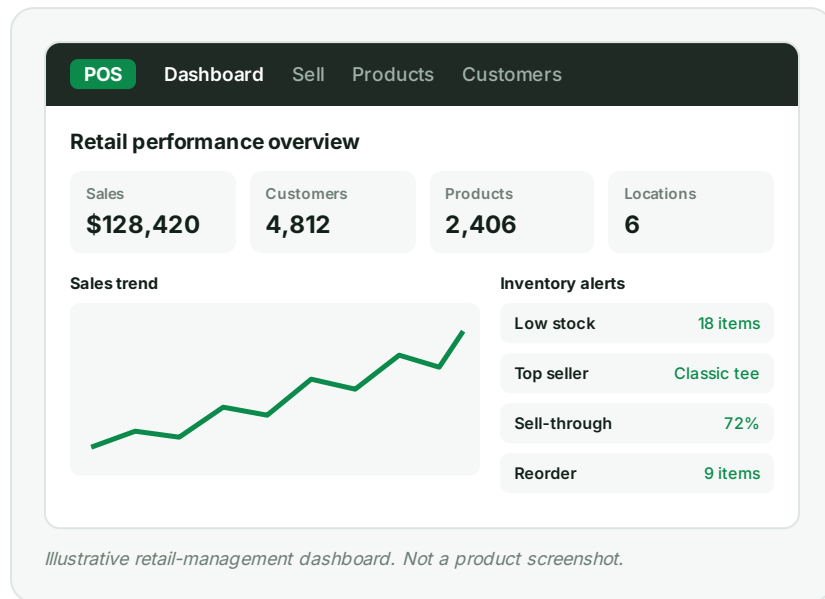
Point of sale, inventory, reporting and customer management in the cloud, later extending into ecommerce and omnichannel retail.

## Global from New Zealand

Founded in Auckland, Vend was already serving retailers across Australia, North America, the UK and other markets by 2014-15.

## A true SaaS growth model

Growth was measured in leads, free trials, activation, paying customers and monthly recurring revenue, not one-off transactions.



# Traffic was growing. The engine needed to mature.

**5,500**

trial accounts per month in the  
2014-15 working baseline

**25-30%**

of monthly trial accounts came from  
Google

## 01 Google was already a material channel

Search was a major source of trials, but both paid and organic search were starting to reach efficiency ceilings.

## 02 Funnel quality mattered more than volume

The focus moved from maximising trial numbers to marketing-qualified leads, better buying-stage journeys and stronger activation.

## 03 Every market had its own economics

Spend, lead share, cost per acquisition and activation varied widely by country, so decisions had to be made market by market rather than through one global playbook.

# From clicks to the full SaaS revenue cycle



Top of funnel: where search success is often measured

Bottom of funnel: where SaaS revenue is earned

## 01

### Journey design

Map visitors from anonymous through engaged lead, sales lead, opportunity and won, then match content and conversion paths to buying intent.

## 02

### Measurement

Connect campaign activity to downstream return on investment through Marketo and improve data accuracy across lead types and markets.

## 03

### Conversion

Reduce signup friction, introduce differentiated landing paths and make conversion rate optimisation an ongoing discipline, not a campaign afterthought.

# Global growth as a portfolio of market economics

| MARKET         | SHARE OF SPEND               | SHARE OF LEADS               | LEAD RETURN* | WHAT IT SHOWED                       |
|----------------|------------------------------|------------------------------|--------------|--------------------------------------|
| Australia      | <div><div></div></div> 14.3% | <div><div></div></div> 24.6% | 1.7x         | Highest activation ratio             |
| United Kingdom | <div><div></div></div> 20.0% | <div><div></div></div> 18.3% | 0.9x         | Growth supported by local investment |
| North America  | <div><div></div></div> 38.5% | <div><div></div></div> 25.9% | 0.7x         | Search CPA \$60, display CPA \$90    |
| Rest of world  | <div><div></div></div> 3.4%  | <div><div></div></div> 6.2%  | 1.8x         | Low CPA, good activation             |

**KEY** Australia and the rest of the world returned more lead share than spend share, while North America needed the heaviest investment per lead. Budget decisions were made market by market.

# A more mature acquisition operating system

01

## Campaign architecture

Tighter ad groups, vertical segmentation, and geographic and time-of-day optimisation, backed by disciplined A/B testing.

02

## Mobile and video

A dedicated mobile strategy, video campaigns, and tests designed to drive app installs and usage.

03

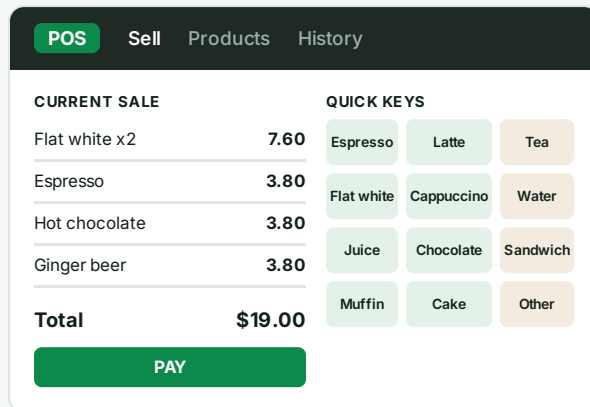
## Landing-page optimisation

A move toward one-step signup, continuous landing-page testing and separate conversion paths for different lead types.

04

## Lifecycle marketing

Beyond trial signups into pre-trial leads, newsletters, ebooks and webinars, each nurtured by buying stage.



*Illustrative cloud point-of-sale screen, the kind of product being marketed.*

# A growth partnership across the whole SaaS funnel

01

## Commercial problem-solving

Linked acquisition spend to trials, activation, recurring revenue and expansion into new markets.

02

## Cross-functional SaaS thinking

Covered customer journey, lifecycle, conversion, analytics, mobile, content, display, video and market prioritisation.

03

## Repeatable experience

Alongside Xero, Vend was a second direct SaaS client relationship in my Google career, with a different product, buyer and growth challenge.



The work was about helping a young SaaS company decide where each dollar of acquisition would create the most recurring revenue, one market at a time.

# Evidence base

- |           |                                                  |                                                                                                  |
|-----------|--------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>01</b> | <b>Primary evidence</b><br>2014–15               | Vend customer acquisition and search engine marketing working deck.                              |
| <b>02</b> | <b>TechCrunch</b><br>25 March 2014               | Vend raised US\$20m, served 10,000+ stores in 100 countries and planned international expansion. |
| <b>03</b> | <b>Silicon / TechWeekEurope</b><br>21 March 2015 | Vend described itself as a cloud point-of-sale platform with customers in 15,000+ stores.        |
| <b>04</b> | <b>Inside Retail NZ</b><br>4 June 2015           | Point of sale, inventory, reporting and ecommerce or omnichannel proposition.                    |
| <b>05</b> | <b>Lightspeed</b><br>11 March 2021               | Acquisition announcement, describing Vend as cloud-based retail management software.             |



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